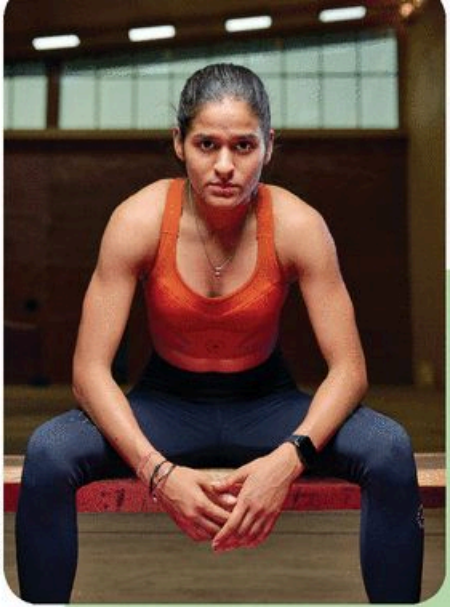


SUDHIR DAMERLA

> **"Shaili is a natural talent and has keen observation and the right attitude to be a world-level athlete. She is a quick learner with an indomitable fighting spirit"**
>
> **ANJU BOBBY GEORGE**
> *Asian Games gold medallist*

SHAILI SINGH, 17

Athlete (Long jump), Jhansi, **Uttar Pradesh**

A LEAP OF FAITH

In August, when Shaili Singh won the silver for long jump at the Under 20 World Athletics Championships in Nairobi, she cried. They weren't tears of joy, but regret. Despite a career best 6.59 metres, the teenager missed the gold by a centimetre. "There were a lot of expectations that I'd get a gold and the national anthem would play in the stadium," says Singh, the junior national record holder. This hunger to win is one reason why many see her as the next new star of Indian athletics. The expectations don't bog her down. "I thrive on it, in fact, I am more energised," says Singh. "I feel I have to do more."

Singh was 13 when her talent caught the eyes of India's most accomplished long jumper Anju Bobby George and her husband-coach Robert George. They invited the girl from a village near Jhansi to move to Bengaluru for coaching and training.

The year 2022 will be crucial as Singh looks to qualify for the Asian Games and the Commonwealth Games. To qualify for the latter, she will need to clear the 6.82 mark. Her coach Robert George believes she can even clear the 7-metre mark, and be an Olympics contender. "If he has faith and I give my 100 per cent, I can do it," she says. ■

–Suhani Singh

DIET ANOTHER DAY Shaili loves her food. **"*Kuchh bhi khila dijiye, main sab kha loongi* (Give me anything, I will eat it all)," says the long-legged athlete.**